

The Internet is Dead... and we have Killed it:

Reigniting Analogue Communities to Cope with Social Isolation

Introduction

The Dead Internet Theory (DIT) is a conspiracy theory that originated around 2017. It claimed that the internet was “dominated by non-human activity” and triggered a “decline in authentic human interaction” online. It has gathered more traction in the past few years as the internet is increasingly homogenized, and there is a multiplication of bots, scams, algorithms, and AI generated content online.¹ This essay focuses on the issues arising from the fact that user engagement and commodification are prioritized over genuine *organic* connections. Many studies show that the demographic most affected by this evolution is youth, and that their emotional relation to the online world affects dependency rates on social media.^{2 3 4} It is so influential that youth would sometimes call themselves “chronically online”, which has a wide range of meanings. From referencing social media niche trending content in social interactions, to feeling disconnected from peers because of the lack of common interests or different ways of building connections. Social media dependencies, in turn, affect the greatly mental health of users. Thus, an AI-driven dead internet could push people further into isolation through echo-chambers and socio-political mistrust. This essay proposes a solution to leverage this clash between demography, politics and AI into an opportunity to reignite the importance of analogue communities in people’s lives.

Go Analog, a Concept

Imagine: you see a funny video and send it to a couple of friends. Scroll, you see an ad. Scroll once again, and you stop a moment to read a voluntarily absurd text on a colourful background with upbeat music. On the next scroll, your screen reads “you have listened to this song [30] times in the past week”, “you have scrolled through [87] posts since you opened the app”, “#darkacademia is the most liked aesthetic of your profile this month, you could be interested in reading Babel by R.F. Kuang”.

¹ Muzumdar et al (2025). “The Dead Internet Theory: A Survey on Artificial Interactions and the Future of Social Media”, *Asian Journal of Research in Computer Science*.

² Li et al (2025). “The relationship between interpersonal security and social media dependence: a moderated mediation model”, *Frontiers*.

³ Dong et al (2025). “Exploring the relationship between social media dependence and internet addiction among college students from a bibliometric perspective”, *Frontiers*.

⁴ Ardelia et al (2025). “TATA KELOLA DIGITAL DALAM MANAJEMEN PEMBANGUNAN TERHADAP CHRONICALLY ONLINE DI INDONESIA”, *Universitas Padjadjaran*.

Users need encouragement to approach social media mindfully, rather than exclusively consuming their content. Reminders could be shown to highlight repetitive behaviours or specific trends, according to the needs of the user. This is a concept for a new application, which would include also a web extension. First, it would draw knowledge from the content consumed, such as the most liked genre of music, philosophy of life or aesthetics, or even interests in terms of art, hobbies or sports, community niches. *Is this person “Stoicism, healthy lifestyle and gym rat” or “Bubblegum pop, nail arts and Y2K”?* Then, it would incorporate AI generated posts to the content seen on the applications when scrolling. Beyond flagging how much time is spent on the application, or which specific content is repetitively interacted with, it would propose ideas for offline engagement with the topics. For instance, how to play a TikTok famous tune on an instrument, or which method and tools are used to match influencers.

“After noticing your interest in Stoicism, we recommend reading On Benefits by Seneca.” Online stoicism has become quite famous, but this strand of philosophy is often misinterpreted as a way of being indifferent to people and their emotions. While justice, rationality and avoiding excesses are prioritized, attachment and kindness towards others are seen as inherent and fundamental to human experience.

On the application itself, there would be the possibility to choose between two modes, one attractive and one underwhelming, to cater to the different needs and expectations of the users. The former would use similar methods than those of social media to maximize catching the attention of the users, functioning as a wakeup call. The latter, on the contrary, would use fonts, colours and syntax that are less stimulating. This time, catering to people who would be more advanced on the path to healthier digital consumption and self-regularize better. The in-app experience also leverages AI tools to create content and links that would connect people that are geographically close, proposing offline activities locally. Furthermore, different books, musical instruments, or exploration of new hobbies, would be recommended in line with the patterns of online interests. To support the user’s mental process, personally crafted advice, as well as personal coaching, to go offline, and support groups would be made accessible. It is not a wellness application or alternative to therapy, rather a tool to explore new activities, find events to connect with people outside of one’s digital bubble. As it would be a non-profit project and community-oriented, it would focus on small gatherings with high personal investment such as book clubs in the area, sports or music groups or charity events.

Impact Facing Disruptions

People’s views on what a community is have evolved greatly with the popularization of social media. What is considered a community no longer related to a locality, within neighbourhoods or

villages, but rather to algorithm-led homogenization of creativity, thought and interests. Youth are more likely to be stuck into echo chambers and only consuming content that attracts their attention or having interactions with like-minded people. Many digital media consumers are suffering from no longer being challenged in their niche or lacking representation from other paths of life. This derives the importance of going analogue and being reminded that “Inconvenience is the cost of community”, that there are nuanced or contradicting views to one’s own, but also potential support systems, representation of the elderly or ideas that are different from one’s own.⁵

The multiple labels that split categories on the internet and the arcane feelings of foreignness that stem from facing opposite views relate to Lauren Berlant’s concept of biopolitical displacement but could be considered in this context as a digital-political displacement. It leads many people to develop “extreme defensive hypervigilance, a multiplicity of speculations and thoughts about what threatens and who’s to blame”.⁶ A plethora of preexisting conditions, such as feelings of social alienation or emotional negativity, moves people through Moghaddam’s floors of extremism. The distinction between the first and the second floors is that people no longer try to find solutions to socio-political issues, but rather start choosing an enemy, someone who is responsible.⁷ It fuels an “us versus them” mentality that spills over to different areas of life. Vulnerabilities cannot be undermined, specifically since youth started to turn to generative AI for mental health advice and emotional support.⁸ Besides, youth have less freedom and independence than previous generations, notably because of parental anxieties and over-supervision, which leads to feelings of unhappiness.⁹ The increased reliance on digital methods to find reassurance may disconnect individuals further from their community and society as a whole. The latter further enhances the risks of Sidestepping Inhibitory Mechanisms, which is found on the fifth floor of terrorism.¹⁰

Beyond mental health and socio-political impacts. Reigniting the feeling of belonging in local communities is crucial in an increasingly connected world. This concept aims to foster mutual understanding and has the potential to reduce political polarization or radicalization through alienation.¹¹ Voluntarily taking time to engage analogically with peers is a way to reconnect with lived experiences in the offline world and facing local challenges and needs. New legal frameworks

⁵ Morgan (2025). “Is inconvenience the cost of community?”, *Dazed*.

⁶ Berlant (2022). *on the inconvenience of other people*.

⁷ Moghaddam (2005). “The Staircase to Terrorism”, *American Psychologist*.

⁸ McBain et al (2025). Use of Generative AI for Mental Health Advice Among US Adolescents and Young Adults”, *JAMA Network Open*.

⁹ Sterkaj (2024). “Young people are getting unhappier – a lack of childhood freedom and independence may be partly to blame”, *The Conversation*.

¹⁰ Moghaddam (2005). “The Staircase to Terrorism”, *American Psychologist*.

¹¹ Richter (2025). “Don’t blame the algorithms for online polarization”, *Science*.

and official strategies are flourishing around the world, such as in Australia, in European Union, and in the United Nations Development Programme. For instance, in 2025, Sydney enacted a law to limit the use of online platforms to children under 16 years old.¹² Reports by the EU and the UNDP offer a starting point to risks social media and AI trigger in relation to youth.¹³ ¹⁴Digital and social natives will need to find new keys to thrive in their lives while managing an intricate balance between the online and offline world.

Modern Problems Require Modern Solutions

Can AI methods really solve AI issues?

Using new technologies as a cure for the wrongs that originated from them is quite counterintuitive at first sight. However, given many people's jobs, leisure and private life are linked to digital technologies, many could not realistically fully end their consumption of online media. Thus, adding features to alleviate dependencies is the best coping solution on the short and medium-term. This application concept is similar to methods of tailoring security mechanisms to the online experience. Since a fully disconnected life is impossible, the stakes are high to temperate misuses. Moreover, there is an undeniable time constraint, as technologies will increasingly be exploited by malevolent actors to carry out specific political agendas. Generative AI will increase both the rate and precision of radical thought and methods' dissemination through social media, notably thanks to sycophantic tendencies. They tend to create emotional connections, and reassurance amongst users, in particular if they are already sensitive to such inputs. The digital world could turn into a "chessboard where AI plays both sides – terrorist and counterterrorist".¹⁵ Ironically or not, the consumers can be understood as the pawns in the game.

Would adding one more application truly support people to distance themselves from their phone? The solution would just be to delete them all, isn't it?

Ultimately, this concept would lead to the deletion of the application, as well as any social media application. It is a first step towards a real-life (offline) extension: the development of an analogue community. Facilitating sharing books, arts and crafts through shipping services and community centers. The full extension to the concept would include local associations, civic organizations, and charities to increase links between people in their localities. Common interests will be found, although nuanced outside of specific niches. They will also serve as bridges between generations,

¹² Australian Government (2025). "Social Media Minimum Age – Fact sheet", *Infrastructure*.

¹³ Laanien and Bol (2025). "Youth and social media", *European Parliamentary Research Service*.

¹⁴ Conceição (2025). "A matter of choice: People and possibilities in the age of AI", *Human Development Report 2025*.

¹⁵ Fishman (2024). "AI's Dual Role in Driving Online Terrorist Content and Counter Strategies: Is NATO Prepared for AI-Enhanced Extremism?", *NATO Strategic Direction*.

political orientations, and many other sources of misunderstanding or disagreement within populations. In itself, this concept hopes to create or strengthen local support systems. It is not an alternative to social media, professional advice, nor local communities. It would be a bridge to refocus on localities for the future, counterbalancing modern hyper-individualism and isolation.

Will social media companies let users temper their content? Specifically, if it is in order to reduce consumption?

Indeed, platforms intend to be as attractive as possible to fuel online interactions. Given that revenue depends on the consumers' online presence, dependence is not a hurdle to the companies, but rather a marketing opportunity. The development of echo chambers, lack of fact checking and deep rabbit holes are nothing else than a symptom of online social spheres. Additionally, the terms of service of most applications do not allow external interference. Methods such as modifying the interface of the application are against policy. Alternative ways might be needed to achieve the expected results. For instance, trials could be done with the support of a social media platform and voluntary users. The data collected in the context of this project should be handled in accordance with the GDPR to avoid delicate personal data to be diverted into other uses than of the analogue project concept. The support of mental health professionals and policymakers could support and strengthen the institutional foundations of such interventions into social media ecosystems.

Conclusion

To paraphrase Nietzsche, the Internet is Dead because its foundations have been shattered. Genuine interactions have been replaced by arguments on online forums with bots; users would rather ask ChatGPT or DeepSeek than read and update Wikipedia to share their knowledge. Being able to meet and connect with people from completely different backgrounds was the promise of social media but was annulled by the systematic categorization of people by niche interests, aesthetic or socio-political perspectives. This application concept offers a way to cope with this new version of the Internet and rise above the nihilism and isolation. Since social media is increasingly impacting people's ways of communicating together and building relationships, reigniting community-building is a contemporary challenge. It must be faced before the persuasiveness of sycophantic AI agents get fully integrated in online platforms. Demography, technology and politics may have collided in the trends of online polarization and radicalization, but the leaders of tomorrow cannot let mental health challenges become a matter of national security.